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Calls for cease-fire in Gaza halt California Dems' convention

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SACRAMENTO -- The dozens of young people massed outside the entrance to the California Democratic Party convention Saturday chanted a message for California Democrats who don't support a cease-fire in the Middle East:

"In November, we'll remember!"

Moments later at a forum for the hotly contested Senate race, demonstrators shouted "Cease-fire now!" as Rep. Katie Porter -- who does not support a cease-fire -- was speaking. It took California Democratic Party chair Rusty Hicks walking on stage to demand that "every candidate will be heard" to quiet them.

It was only a temporary muzzling. Moments later, Hicks repeated his message when Rep. Adam Schiff, who also opposes a cease-fire, was speaking. Rep. Barbara Lee is the only top Democratic candidate who backs a cease-fire and is one of only roughly three dozen House members who do so.

"I'm calling for a cease-fire now!" Lee said to punctuate her speech. The crowd of delegates roared their approval. The calm was short-lived. A short time later, dozens of pro-cease-fire demonstrators swarmed inside the hall and drowned out the last part of Senate candidate Lexi Reese's appearance.

At 7:12 p.m., roughly 90 minutes after more than a couple of hundred demonstrators from a nearby march breached convention center security and entered the building, party officials canceled the rest of Saturday evening's program as the center went on lockdown. "Due to circumstances beyond our control, and for the safety and security of our delegates and convention participants, we are canceling tonight's caucus meetings, hospitality suites, and VoteFest taking place at the convention center," said Sherry Yang, communications director for the California Democratic Party.

Afterward, leaders of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus said several Jewish delegates felt it was "unsafe to participate" in the rest of the convention. The statement by the caucus, which is co-chaired by San Francisco state Sen. Scott Wiener and Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel of Encino (Los Angeles County) said protesters were chanting "from the river to the sea," which some interpret as a call for the eradication of Israel.

"We must never allow the Democratic Party to be unsafe for anyone," the caucus statement read. "We fully support the right to protest loudly and vociferously. But storming through security and shutting down a democratic process -- particularly with chants calling for the destruction of Israel and appearing to justify the Hamas attack -- is completely unacceptable."

Hicks said Sunday that the state party has already begun an investigation into Saturday's events. Any delegate who "actively participated or aided in the furtherance of those activities" in violation of the party's code of conduct will be "held accountable," he said.

It was a visceral reminder of how Democrats, who gathered at the party's three-day convention, are struggling with how to talk about the conflict in the Middle East. And of how their inability to do so threatens to weaken their support among young and progressive voters.

"The party needs to reckon with the fact that their complicity and silence will lose them a generation of voters," said Farah Ard'Lana, a 22-year-old organizer with Palestine Youth Movement and Students for Justice in Palestine at Sacramento State University, who was leading the chants outside the convention. "These politicians say that they

support us, but they're empty words. They're not following their morals."

It is not that young Democrats, in particular, are going to vote for Donald Trump. The concern among Democrats is that they might vote for a third-party candidate or just not cast a ballot.

And that could be fatal to President Joe Biden's reelection bid. He needs strong turnout from young voters and communities of color to win.

The question of a cease-fire is what is dividing Democrats. More moderate members of the party mostly support Biden's opposition to a cease-fire. Progressives want a cease-fire, but stress that their position isn't an anti-Israel one. It is one rooted in concern about the plight of the 11,000 Gazans killed, according to Gazan health officials, after the Oct. 7 attack by Hamas militants that killed about 1,200 Israelis, according to Israeli officials.

On Saturday, while the Sacramento demonstrations were going on, the Washington Post reported that the U.S, Israel and Hamas had agreed to a tentative agreement that would free dozens of women and children held hostage in Gaza in exchange for a five-day pause in the war. The White House denied that a deal had been reached as of Saturday night.

Navigating the million layers of nuance and millennia of history behind the conflict is too daunting for many to touch in this era of binary politics. So, many Democratic officeholders and office-seekers are tiptoeing around the issue, fearful of a verbal misstep that could offend one side or the other -- especially in an election year when Congress and the White House will probably be decided by slim margins.

"We just want to ensure that everyone is simply heard," Hicks said Friday at the start of the convention. He chalked up the disagreements to Democrats being Democrats. "Yes, it is occasionally rambunctious. Yes, folks do get passionate. But it's our job as leaders within our party to ensure that everyone has their voice heard."

Hicks downplayed whether the controversy might affect Democratic House candidates in battleground districts. Flipping several battleground House seats in California is key to the Democrats' hopes of retaking the House from Republicans.

"I think there's a long way between here and Election Day in November of 2024," Hicks said.

But the issue is existential to partisans on both sides, which is why many aren't hiding their feelings. Saturday's demonstration at the nation's largest Democratic Party convention, following the shutdown of the Bay Bridge days earlier during the APEC gathering of world leaders, is the latest high-profile act by cease-fire supporters. Late Saturday afternoon, after the Senate candidates had spoken, hundreds of demonstrators from a pro-cease-fire march and rally outside the convention breached the convention security and filled a large mezzanine in the center.

Even Gov. Gavin Newsom, who didn't attend the convention, wasn't spared by cease-fire supporters. Alluding to Newsom's surprise trip to Israel last month, demonstrators chanted, "Newsom, Newsom, you can't hide! We charge you with genocide." Newsom has said he is also working to get relief supplies to Gaza.

State convention delegates are typically more left-leaning than the general Democratic Party voters, which in part explains the demonstration.

But support for Palestinians is growing -- particularly among young voters. An NPR/PBS NewsHour/Marist College survey released last week found that 50% of Gen Z and Millennial respondents sympathized more with the Palestinian people than with Israel, while older voters were more sympathetic to Israel. The survey found that 38% of the respondents said that Israel's military response to Hamas has been too much -- up from 26% in the week after the Oct. 7 attack. Overall, Democratic sympathies were evenly split.

There were some efforts to seek a middle ground of sorts at the convention. At one session before the full convention, a Muslim leader and a rabbi stood together to acknowledge the thousands who have died on both

sides.

The party's Progressive Caucus, its largest internal affinity group, held a panel discussion called "Understanding Trauma: Palestinian Humanity and Unraveling Antisemitism in the Face of Genocide."

"If we don't center the most vulnerable among us every single time, in every situation, and have deep empathy and compassion, then we are somewhat complicit in that oppression for not speaking up," Progressive Caucus chair Fatima Iqbal-Zubair said.

Schiff, who supports the administration's opposition to a cease-fire, said the U.S. role in the war is to "help Israel protect itself against further Hamas attacks. But also urge Israel to make every effort to avoid civilian loss of life."

As for how to explain that position to young voters who might be considering not voting for Democrats, Schiff said, "You have to make the case to be able to do two things at once -- which is to respect the loss of lives, both Israeli and Palestinian. The need for peace. The need for the return of hostages. The need to have a governance in Gaza that is not run by terrorists. And that all of these things are prerequisites to peace."

Lee, a cease-fire supporter, said "everyone has a right to their own opinion in a democracy."

"However," Lee continued, "we have to also understand the dangers of not voting for President Biden and Kamala Harris, because one vote not for them is a vote for Donald Trump. And this man, Donald Trump, wants to lead this country into an autocratic government."

Other House Democrats who are campaigning in moderate districts, such as Adam Gray, a former Central Valley Assembly member, are trying to put the issue in context in regions like his where "a lot of people live paycheck to paycheck. So you can imagine what's top of mind for them, right? But that doesn't make it any less important."

Gray said: "We have to hold the line in supportive democratic institutions, period. We have to support Ukraine. We have to support Israel. At the same time, we don't have to pretend that holding the line and supporting our allies and supporting democracy in the world doesn't mean we can't empathize for the communities that are suffering.

"Because in war, there are no winners on both sides. Innocent people die."

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